



Synopsys in 2012, Rajeev helped fund or form 28 companies as an entrepreneur-angel-investor.

Rajeev attributes his business sense and the desire to understand business to his mother. “I do believe some people have a natural inclination for business—it is in their DNA. I probably have some of that business DNA from my mum. Negotiation and decision-making are learned skills, but the desire to understand business and how it works comes from within.”

His dad continued to encourage him. “He was always my biggest fan,” he says. Rajeev’s mother finally came around when a local Kochi newspaper wrote a story about Magma going public. “It was only when she read that news report that she concluded I had finally achieved something in life,” he jests.

The gardener never smells his roses!

Not many people know, but tough boss Rajeev is up at 5:30 AM every Saturday morning. Assisted by two gardeners, the founder of Clear Ventures can be seen working for the next three to five hours, forgetting his gloves, tending to his rose garden with around 3000 rose bushes! “It has become a very large private rose



Rajeev's rose garden

garden,” he claims proudly.

The garden, which is more than two decades old, sprouted into existence on a flight to Portland, Oregon, immediately after Magma went public. “I was going for an investor meeting. On the flight, I was sitting next to a man who was flipping through pictures of roses,” he narrates. Upon enquiring, the man revealed that he ran a rose nursery and invited Rajeev to visit. “I saw his roses and, impressed, I told him I would buy one of each variety. I thought he had maybe 20 varieties—turns out he had 400! And so, he shipped all 400 varieties to me,” he laughs.

Despite the hours and the effort, Rajeev doesn’t ever stop to smell the roses! “I just keep growing them and fixing issues as they come up. I focus on mending whatever needs attention, but I do not believe in staying there to marvel at their beauty. That is for others to do, while I move on to the next thing,” he shares.

Interestingly, Rajeev’s wife, Geetha, is allergic to roses and needs to take anti-allergy drugs to spend time in the garden. “She jokes that I maintain the garden just to keep her out of it! This garden is therapeutic for me. It keeps me grounded and

gives me the break that I need,” he says.

Over time, Rajeev expanded the garden to include a greenhouse with papaya, mango, and other plants that remind him of his home in Kerala. “It is more than just a rose garden—it has become a bit of a Kerala greenhouse now!”

From follower to leader, learner to guide

A leader is not born; a leader learns and leads.

Rajeev too spent the next decade at Magma learning from his mistakes and striving to be the guide for his peers, just as Prof. P.S. Bhatt and Ed Vopni had been for him. The road was rocky, and the learning never seemed to end, but somehow Rajeev never took the same turn twice, thus avoiding going in circles, and moved on to the path of leadership.

“A leader needs to be tough and empathetic at the same time. I reached this level of thinking by the third startup,” he states.

At Magma, Rajeev built a strong internal team of engineers and experts who contributed to the company’s success and drove innovation in areas like physical synthesis, design for manufacturability, and sign-off tools. Young professionals hired by Rajeev are today working as C-suite executives, architects, and leaders at top technology firms in Silicon Valley.

Sharing his experiences, he recalls hiring Anirudh Devgan, the current President and CEO of Cadence Design Systems, who presented Rajeev with a startup idea. “I immediately realised he was very sharp and offered him a position at Magma. Within three months of joining, it was clear that he was exceptional, fair, and very data-driven,

Some Favourites of Rajeev

Favourite Food: Korean, Japanese, or Kerala

Favourite Drink: Water

Favourite Travel Destination: Norway

Favourite Book: Art of War by Sun Tzu

Favourite Sport: Cricket

Real-Life Role Model: Virat Kohli or Sunil Gavaskar

Real-Life Model as a VC: Mark Perry, NEA partner (Gentleman VC)